

A CITY THAT WORKS

A citizens' framework for Victoria 2026. Proven ideas. Measurable results.

acitythatworks.ca

Version 1.9.1

Every measure costed and sourced

THE PROBLEM IN 30 SECONDS

31%

operating budget growth
in three years

9.34%

residential tax rise in 2026,
not the 7.28% headline

\$750

policing per resident,
the highest in BC

61

missing-middle permits
in 2024, target was 150

Four consecutive years above inflation plus population growth, every one of them closed with one-time measures rather than structural savings. No competitive benchmarking. No zero-based reviews. No published household bill. Victoria does not need to spend more. It needs to spend smarter.

It is a Tuesday evening in the spring of 2030 and you are walking down Pandora Avenue on purpose, which is not a sentence anyone could have written in 2026. The lights stay on until morning and nobody is watching you walk home. Unsheltered homelessness is down by half, and the corridor people crossed the street to avoid is the one they walk their kids down.

VICTORIA IN 2030, IF THIS FRAMEWORK IS DELIVERED

WHAT WE WOULD DO

FOUNDATION

- Government-to-government working tables** with the Songhees and the Esquimalt Nations, on a standing quarterly cadence. Not a gesture, an operating relationship.

LIVEABLE

- 12,000 net new homes by 2030**, with composition targets: 25% missing middle, 20% three-bedroom or larger. Composition is the problem, not volume.
- Published permit times.** Simple under 6 weeks, complex under 6 months, rezoning under 9 months. Plus a pattern book of pre-approved designs and a 24-month amnesty for the suites that already exist.
- Childcare and family doctors.** Fast-track permits and below-market City space for both. First-hour free parking, and a walking city with a published sidewalk gap inventory.

SAFE

- Bylaw enforcement 6 AM to 10 PM, seven days**, funded by managed-competition savings rather than by raising taxes or raiding reserves.
- One Downtown Public Order Team.** Police, bylaw, sanitation and outreach under a single command, with a dashboard published weekly.
- Unsheltered homelessness cut in half**, capacity first and enforcement second, with a throughput programme that frees supportive units rather than only adding to them. Cost per placement published quarterly.
- Relentless with the dangerous, compassionate with the vulnerable.** 24% of all 2022 police calls came from 19 addresses. Reclaim the Inner Harbour, the Pandora corridor and Beacon Hill Park.

BEAUTIFUL

- Smart LED streetlights.** No City cameras, no audio surveillance, no behavioural AI. Better lighting cuts crime about 14% and needs nobody watched.
- Heritage protected**, street furniture restored, Bastion Square pedestrianized, 5,000 trees and a canopy target of 35% by 2035.
- One signature public space**, chosen by residents from three costed options and approved at a referendum before a shovel moves.

WELL-MANAGED

- A tax glide path on the number you actually pay.** 6.5%, then 5%, then inflation plus growth, capped on the residential rate rather than on total revenue.
- Zero-based review of all 200+ programs**, and competitive testing on waste and street cleaning that City crews can win. Workers protected either way.
- The Household Bill.** One published number covering property tax plus water, sewer, solid waste and stormwater, with a five-year forward view.

DEMOCRATIC

- A referendum on every new capital project over \$25M**, and an Integrity Commissioner with the governance-review recommendations actually implemented.
- A quarterly performance dashboard.** Permits, potholes, crime, housing, budget variance, debt per household. Plain language, no spin.
- A lobbyist registry for development files**, no fee to file a freedom-of-information request, and council pay changes that take effect only after the next election.

12 COMMITMENTS, MEASURED EVERY QUARTER

1	New homes	12,000+ net new by 2030
2	Rental vacancy	5%
3	Unsheltered homelessness	down 50%
4	Crime severity	down 15% by 2030
5	Graffiti removed in 48h	90%
6	Permit speed	published target per category
7	Green mobility	60% of trips non-auto
8	Serious-injury collisions	down 50% by 2030
9	Downtown storefront vacancy	11% to 5%
10	Trees and canopy	5,000 planted, 35% by 2035
11	Community GHG	down 50% by 2030
12	Stormwater	oldest pipes replaced first

THE MATH

Managed competition, waste and cleaning	+\$2.4M / yr
Zero-based budget review	+\$3 to 6M / yr
Admin efficiency, attrition and tech	+\$1.9 to 4M / yr
New property tax, 12,000 homes	+\$8 to 15M / yr
Smart streetlighting	+\$0.5 to 1M / yr
Less every new cost this plan creates	-\$13.3 to 18.0M / yr

Net headroom, central **+\$4.3 to 14.0M / yr**

Pessimistic case, published anyway *about -\$0.3M / yr*

Year one is a fraction of steady state and the glide path says so. Both cases are published, because a framework that demands outcome metrics from a council owes them itself.

HOW A MAJOR PROJECT GETS DECIDED

- Consult locally** what residents say needs to improve
- Design with experts** engineers, planners, affected residents
- Visualize and publish** imagery and GIS analysis, before a dollar is spent
- Vote, if over \$25M** binding, under BC statutory process
- Report quarterly** on time, on budget, or explain why not

The Dowler Place file showed what happens when there is no required process. So we wrote one down.

WHAT THIS IS

Non-partisan and open. Costed, sourced and measurable. Reported every quarter. Free for any candidate to adopt in whole, in part, or as a starting point.

WHAT IT IS NOT

Not a political party. Not a candidate slate. Not City surveillance cameras. Not a machine deciding about a person. Not ideology dressed as policy.